



HUSTLE STUDIO TOOLKIT

The AI-First Freelancer Playbook

Prompts, client workflows and a weekly system for freelancers 1-5 years in

Contents

01 The AI-First Freelancer Playbook

02 AI Foundations for Freelancers

03 Prompt Library

04 Client Workflows

05 Proposals & Rate Templates

06 The Weekly AI System

The AI-First Freelancer Playbook

Use AI to do more, charge more, and win better clients

Welcome

This playbook is a practical operating system for freelancers who want to use AI tools — ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, and others — not as a gimmick, but as a genuine force multiplier.

Most freelancers who "try AI" use it to write a few emails and then abandon it. This playbook is different. It gives you a repeatable system for every part of your business: finding clients, scoping projects, doing the work, communicating results, and growing.

What's Inside

File	What you'll get
01 – AI Foundations	The mindset shift that separates high earners from time-wasters
02 – Prompt Library	55 copy-paste prompts, organized by situation
03 – Client Workflows	Step-by-step AI-powered processes for each client phase
04 – Proposals & Rate Templates	Winning proposal structure + a rate-setting worksheet
05 – Weekly AI System	The 90-minute weekly review that keeps you growing

How to Use This Playbook

1. **Read 01 first.** The mindset section is short but it changes how you use everything else.
2. **Bookmark 02.** The prompt library is your daily reference. You'll return to it constantly.
3. **Apply 03 to your next client.** Walk through the workflow on a real project — it clicks fast.

4. **Use 04 for your next proposal.** The structure alone will improve your close rate.
 5. **Set a recurring calendar block for 05.** 90 minutes, every Friday.
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A Note on AI Tools

The prompts in this playbook are written to work with any instruction-following AI (ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, Copilot, etc.). You don't need a paid subscription to start — free tiers are enough for most tasks. Paid tiers are worth it once you're using AI daily.

The most important thing: **AI is a draft machine, not a decision maker.** Every output needs your judgment and your voice. The goal is to spend 20% of the time getting to 80% quality, then spend your creative energy on the remaining 20% that only you can do.

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01 – AI Foundations for Freelancers

The mindset shift that separates high earners from people who gave up

The Core Insight

Freelancers who use AI well don't use it to replace their thinking. They use it to **compress the low-value parts of their workflow** so their thinking time goes entirely to high-value work.

Low-value (time-consuming but not what clients pay for):

- First drafts of emails, proposals, and reports
- Research and competitive analysis
- Reformatting, summarizing, and restructuring content
- Brainstorming options before deciding
- Writing project briefs and SOWs

High-value (where your expertise and judgment live):

- Understanding what the client actually needs
- Making the key creative or strategic decision
- Building trust and the relationship
- Spotting what's missing or wrong in a draft
- Negotiating scope and rate

The goal is to spend **more** time on the second list and **less** on the first.

The Three Laws of Freelancer AI Use

Law 1: Context is everything

AI output quality is directly proportional to the context you give it. A lazy prompt gets a generic output. A prompt that includes:

- What you're trying to achieve
- Who the audience is

- What constraints exist
- What format you need
- What "good" looks like

...gets something you can actually use.

Before you prompt: spend 60 seconds writing down these five things. You'll save 20 minutes of iteration.

Law 2: Edit, never accept

Treat every AI output as a first draft written by a smart but junior assistant who doesn't know your client. Your job is always to edit, not to approve. This matters for two reasons:

1. **Quality:** AI drafts often miss nuance, use filler phrases, or get tone wrong. Your edit is the product.
2. **Voice:** Clients hire *you*. If your deliverables sound like everyone else's AI output, you lose your competitive advantage.

A useful rule: if you can't edit an output confidently, you don't understand the topic well enough yet. That's fine — use AI to learn faster, then edit from a place of knowledge.

Law 3: Build a prompt inventory

Every time you write a prompt that produces a good output, save it. Over time, you build a personal library that compounds — each new client benefits from everything you've learned with previous clients. This playbook gives you a starting library; your job is to keep adding to it.

Setting Up Your AI Workflow

Step 1: Pick one primary tool

Don't try to juggle five AI tools at once. Pick one (ChatGPT, Claude, or Gemini are all excellent in 2026) and become expert at it before adding others. The leverage is in depth, not breadth.

Step 2: Create a "context document"

Keep a short document (under 500 words) that describes:

- Your freelance specialty and niche

- Your typical client profile
- Your tone and communication style
- Things you never do / always do

Paste this at the start of any session where you're working on client-facing content. It dramatically improves output quality.

Example context document:

I'm a freelance B2B copywriter specializing in SaaS companies. My clients are typically Series A–C startups with 10–100 employees. My writing is clear, direct, and avoids jargon and corporate buzzwords. I write in second person ("you") and use short paragraphs. I never use clichés like "leverage" or "synergy." My goal is always to drive a specific action, not just to inform.

Step 3: Time-box AI sessions

Don't open an AI chat and drift. Decide in advance: "I'm going to use AI for the next 25 minutes to draft this proposal section." Set a timer. AI is remarkably easy to get lost in — treat it like any other tool.

Step 4: Audit your workflow monthly

Once a month, look at where you spent time that week. Ask: "Which of these could AI have helped with?" The answer is almost always more than you acted on.

The Compounding Effect

Working with AI is a skill like any other: the more deliberately you practice, the better your results get — not because the AI gets smarter, but because you do. Your prompts improve, your editing speed improves, and you learn what AI is and isn't good at for your specific work.

This is a skill. Invest in it, and it compounds.

Continue to: 02 – Prompt Library →

02 – Prompt Library

55 copy-paste prompts for every part of your freelance business

How to Use This Library

Each prompt has a **[BRACKET]** for things you need to fill in. Some prompts have optional additions marked with *(optional)*.

Before using any prompt, paste your context document (see 01 – AI Foundations) at the top of the conversation. Then use the prompt. You'll get dramatically better results.

Section A: Client Discovery & Outreach (8 prompts)

A1 – Research a prospect

I'm a freelance [YOUR SPECIALTY] and I'm about to reach out to [COMPANY NAME], a [BRIEF DESCRIPTION].

Research their likely pain points, what they value in vendors, and what I should know before contacting them. Focus on what's relevant to my services. Format as a bulleted brief I can review in 3 minutes.

A2 – Write a cold outreach email

Write a short, non-spammy cold outreach email from me to [NAME], [TITLE] at [COMPANY].

Context:

- My specialty: [YOUR SPECIALTY]
- Why I'm reaching out to them specifically: [REASON – be specific, e.g., "I saw their recent rebrand and noticed the website copy hasn't been updated"]
- One relevant result I've achieved for a similar client: [RESULT]
- Desired outcome: a 20-minute call

Rules: no buzzwords, no flattery, no "I hope this email finds you well." Keep it under 120 words. Sound like a human, not a marketing email.

A3 – Follow-up email (no response)

I sent a cold outreach email to [NAME] at [COMPANY] [X DAYS] ago and haven't heard back.

Original email: [PASTE EMAIL]

Write a short, non-pushy follow-up. Acknowledge I haven't heard back, add one new piece of value or context (suggest something based on the original email), and make it easy to respond yes or no. Under 80 words.

A4 – LinkedIn connection request

Write a LinkedIn connection request to [NAME], [TITLE] at [COMPANY].

Context: [BRIEF REASON YOU'RE CONNECTING – e.g., "we met at a conference," "I admire their work on X," "I'm in the same niche"]

Rules: under 300 characters, no selling, no generic "I'd like to add you to my network." Should feel genuine and specific.

A5 – Profile positioning statement

Help me write a positioning statement for my freelance profile (LinkedIn headline or website tagline).

My specialty: [SPECIALTY]

The type of client I serve best: [CLIENT TYPE]

The main result I help them achieve: [RESULT]

My differentiator vs. other freelancers: [WHAT MAKES YOU DIFFERENT]

Write 5 variations from 10 to 25 words. Avoid jargon. Focus on outcomes, not activities.

A6 – Case study outline

I want to write a case study about a project I completed. Help me outline it.

Client type: [TYPE – no names if confidential]

Problem they had: [PROBLEM]

What I did: [YOUR WORK]

Results achieved: [RESULTS – be specific with numbers if possible]

Create a 5-section case study outline (situation, challenge, approach, results, takeaway) with 2–3 bullet points per section I should address. Keep it skimmable.

A7 – Referral request message

Write a brief, natural-sounding message asking a past client for referrals.

Relationship context: [DESCRIBE THE PROJECT AND HOW IT WENT]

What kind of referral I'm looking for: [DESCRIBE IDEAL CLIENT]

Rules: don't be transactional. Make it easy to say yes or no. Under 100 words. Should feel like a genuine request, not a sales script.

A8 – Niche identification exercise

I'm a freelance [BROAD CATEGORY – e.g., "graphic designer" or "marketing consultant"].

Here's what I've worked on in the past: [LIST 5–10 PROJECTS OR CLIENTS]

Here's what I most enjoyed: [DESCRIBE]

Here's where I got the best results: [DESCRIBE]

Based on this, suggest 5 specific niches I could position myself in. For each, describe: (1) who the client is, (2) what specific problem I'd solve, (3) why I'd be competitive in that niche, (4) estimated price range for a typical project.

Section B: Scoping & Proposals (8 prompts)

B1 – Discovery call prep

I have a discovery call with [CLIENT DESCRIPTION] in [X HOURS/DAYS]. They want [BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF WHAT THEY'VE TOLD ME].

Generate 10 discovery questions I should ask to:

1. Fully understand the problem and its business impact
2. Understand their definition of success
3. Surface any red flags or scope risks
4. Understand their timeline, budget range, and decision process

Organize by priority – most important first.

B2 – Scope of work draft

Write a clear scope of work section for a freelance proposal.

Project: [PROJECT DESCRIPTION]

What's included: [LIST DELIVERABLES]

What's NOT included (important): [LIST EXCLUSIONS]

Number of revisions: [NUMBER]

My role vs. client's role: [DESCRIBE WHAT YOU EACH DO]

Format as a professional SOW section I can paste into a proposal document. Use clear, plain language. Include a "Not Included" section explicitly.

B3 – Proposal email (initial send)

Write a short email to send alongside a proposal document.

Context:

- Client: [CLIENT DESCRIPTION]
- Project: [PROJECT SUMMARY]
- Proposal highlights: [2–3 KEY POINTS FROM YOUR PROPOSAL]
- Next step you want: [E.G., "review and reply with questions" or "sign by Friday"]

Rules: under 150 words. Professional but warm. Don't summarize the whole proposal – tease the value and drive the action.

B4 – Handle a scope creep conversation

A client is asking me to [DESCRIBE THE EXTRA REQUEST]. This is outside our original scope, which covered [ORIGINAL SCOPE].

Write a professional, non-confrontational response that:

1. Acknowledges the request positively
2. Notes it's outside our original scope
3. Offers to add it for [PRICE] or in a future phase
4. Keeps the relationship intact

Tone: collaborative, not defensive. Under 150 words.

B5 – Project risk assessment

I'm about to start a project: [PROJECT DESCRIPTION]

Client: [CLIENT TYPE]

Timeline: [TIMELINE]

Budget: [BUDGET]

List the 5 most likely risks that could derail this project, with a brief description of each and a simple mitigation step I could take proactively.

B6 – Project brief template

Create a project brief template I can use to onboard [TYPE OF PROJECT – e.g., "website copywriting" or "brand strategy"] clients.

It should capture: project goals, target audience, competitors, tone/style preferences, key messages, deliverables, timeline, approval process, and any brand assets needed.

Format as a fillable document with short explanatory notes for each field. The client should be able to complete it in 20 minutes.

B7 – Rate justification script

A potential client pushed back on my rate of [YOUR RATE], saying it's higher than what they expected.

My rate is justified because: [2–3 REASONS – experience, results, specialization]

Write a confident, non-defensive response that:

1. Acknowledges their concern
2. Reframes the rate in terms of value (ROI), not hours
3. Offers a clear path forward (either they accept, or you adjust scope to fit their budget)

Under 150 words. No apologizing for the rate.

B8 – Project kickoff agenda

Write a kickoff meeting agenda for a [PROJECT TYPE] project.

Participants: me (freelancer) and [CLIENT DESCRIPTION]

Duration: [X MINUTES]

Project goals: [GOALS]

The agenda should cover: introductions/rapport, project goals alignment, working process and communication norms, timeline and milestones, immediate next steps (who does what before next meeting). Format as a clean agenda I can share with the client in advance.

Section C: Doing the Work (10 prompts)

C1 – Research briefing

I need to research [TOPIC] for a client project. The client is [CLIENT DESCRIPTION] and they need this information to [PURPOSE].

Give me:

1. The 5 most important questions I should answer through my research
2. The most reliable types of sources for each question
3. A suggested research structure (what to tackle first, second, etc.)

Don't do the research yet – just help me plan it efficiently.

C2 – First draft from notes

I have rough notes from [MEETING/RESEARCH/INTERVIEW]. Turn them into a coherent first draft of [DELIVERABLE – e.g., "an executive summary," "a strategy memo," "a website page"].

Notes: [PASTE YOUR NOTES]

Target audience: [AUDIENCE]

Tone: [TONE]

Length: [APPROXIMATE LENGTH]

Keep my key points but organize them logically, fill in transitions, and make it readable. I'll edit heavily – give me a solid structural draft.

C3 – Improve a draft

Here's a draft I've written: [PASTE DRAFT]

Please:

1. Identify the 3 biggest weaknesses (clarity, logic, tone, structure, etc.)
2. Rewrite the weakest section to show how to improve it
3. Give me a list of specific edits to make to the rest

Don't rewrite the whole thing unless I ask – I want to understand the problems and fix them myself.

C4 – Create an outline

I need to write [DELIVERABLE – e.g., "a 2,000-word industry report" / "a 10-slide presentation" / "a 5-email onboarding sequence"].

Topic: [TOPIC]

Audience: [AUDIENCE]

Goal (what should they think/feel/do after): [GOAL]

Key points I need to cover: [LIST]

Create a detailed outline with section headers and 2–3 bullet points per section describing what each part should accomplish.

C5 – Simplify complex content

Here's a complex piece of content: [PASTE CONTENT]

Rewrite it so a [TARGET AUDIENCE – e.g., "small business owner with no technical background"] can understand it in one read.

Rules: no jargon without explanation, use short sentences and paragraphs, use concrete examples where helpful. Target reading level: [GRADE LEVEL, e.g., "8th grade"].

C6 – Generate alternatives

I've written this: [PASTE CONTENT – e.g., a headline, tagline, section, paragraph]

Generate 8 alternative versions that vary in:

- Tone (e.g., more direct, more conversational, more authoritative)
- Approach (e.g., problem-first, solution-first, curiosity-driven)
- Length (short, medium, and long variations)

Label each version with its approach so I can compare easily.

C7 – Summarize research

Here is research I've collected on [TOPIC]: [PASTE RESEARCH OR KEY FINDINGS]

Summarize this into:

1. A 5-bullet executive summary (what matters most)
2. 3 key takeaways relevant to [CLIENT/PROJECT CONTEXT]
3. 2 open questions this research doesn't answer

Keep it tight. I'm using this to brief a client, not publish it.

C8 – Review for consistency

Here are two pieces of content that should match in tone and style:

Piece 1: [PASTE]

Piece 2: [PASTE]

List every inconsistency you find: tone differences, terminology differences, formatting differences, contradictions. Then suggest specific fixes.

C9 – Create a checklist

Create a quality-control checklist for [DELIVERABLE TYPE – e.g., "a brand strategy document" / "a website copywriting project" / "a marketing campaign"].

The checklist should cover: completeness (is everything there?), quality (is it good?), consistency (does it align with brief?), client-readiness (can it be sent as-is?).

Format as a checkbox list I can run through before every delivery. Include 15–25 items.

C10 – Translate jargon for clients

My client doesn't have a background in [YOUR FIELD]. I need to explain [CONCEPT OR PROCESS] to them.

Write a plain-English explanation suitable for a non-expert. Use an analogy if helpful. Anticipate the 2–3 follow-up questions they're most likely to ask, and answer those too. Aim for a 1-minute read.

Section D: Client Communication (10 prompts)

D1 – Project status update

Write a weekly status update email to a client.

Project: [PROJECT NAME]

What I completed this week: [LIST]

What's in progress: [LIST]

What I need from the client: [LIST – if anything]

Any risks or changes to flag: [OR "none"]

Next milestone: [MILESTONE AND DATE]

Format: clear, professional, under 200 words. Use bullet points. Start with a one-line summary of where we stand.

D2 – Deliver a project

Write an email to deliver [DELIVERABLE] to a client.

Context: [BRIEF PROJECT CONTEXT]

What I'm delivering: [DESCRIBE]

Key decisions or trade-offs I made: [1–2 THINGS TO CALL OUT]

What I need from them: [FEEDBACK? APPROVAL? PAYMENT?]

Deadline for response (if any): [DATE OR "none"]

Tone: confident and warm. I'm proud of this work. Under 150 words.

D3 – Handle a critical client

A client gave me critical or negative feedback: "[PASTE THEIR FEEDBACK]"

Write a professional response that:

1. Thanks them for the feedback without being sycophantic
2. Shows I understood their concern (restate it briefly)
3. Explains my original thinking briefly (not defensively)
4. Proposes a concrete next step to resolve it

Tone: calm, collaborative, professional. Not defensive. Not a pushover. Under 150 words.

D4 – Reschedule or delay

I need to tell a client that [DESCRIBE THE DELAY OR CHANGE – e.g., "a deliverable will be 3 days late" / "I need to reschedule our meeting"].

Reason: [HONEST REASON – keep it brief]

What I'm doing to address it: [YOUR MITIGATION PLAN]

New date/timeline: [NEW DATE]

Write a short, direct message that owns the situation without over-explaining. No excuses, just facts and a clear path forward. Under 100 words.

D5 – Say no to a client request

A client is asking me to [DESCRIBE REQUEST]. I need to decline because [YOUR REASON – e.g., "it's outside my expertise," "it would compromise the project," "I don't have bandwidth"].

Write a professional, warm refusal that:

1. Declines clearly (no ambiguity)
2. Explains briefly (one sentence)
3. Offers an alternative where possible
4. Keeps the relationship positive

Under 100 words.

D6 – Close out a project

A project is wrapping up. Write a closing email to the client.

Project summary: [WHAT WE DID]

Results/outcome: [WHAT WAS ACHIEVED]

What they're receiving: [FINAL DELIVERABLES]

Any handoff notes: [THINGS THEY NEED TO KNOW GOING FORWARD]

Optional: open the door to future work

Tone: warm, professional, proud of the work. Under 200 words.

D7 – Ask for a testimonial

A project just ended well. Write a short message asking the client for a testimonial.

Context: [BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF PROJECT AND OUTCOME]

Where I'll use it: [E.G., "my website and LinkedIn"]

Make it easy: offer to write a draft for them to edit *(optional – include this if you want)*

Under 80 words. Feels like a human ask, not a template.

D8 – Raise rates with existing client

I want to raise my rates for a recurring client from [OLD RATE] to [NEW RATE], effective [DATE].

Context:

- How long I've worked with them: [TIME]
- Value I've delivered: [BRIEF SUMMARY]
- Reason for increase: [YOUR REASON – e.g., "market adjustment," "increased expertise," "demand for my work"]

Write a professional, direct message announcing the change that treats them like an adult and doesn't over-apologize. Under 150 words.

D9 – Difficult conversation opener

I need to have a difficult conversation with a client about [DESCRIBE SITUATION – e.g., "they've been unresponsive for 3 weeks," "they're repeatedly missing deadlines on their end," "I think the project is heading in the wrong direction"].

Write an opening message that:

1. Opens the conversation without blame
2. States my concern clearly and factually
3. Invites their perspective
4. Suggests a specific solution or next step

Tone: direct but collaborative. Not passive-aggressive. Not confrontational. Under 150 words.

D10 – Invoice reminder (overdue)

Write a follow-up message for an overdue invoice.

Invoice amount: [AMOUNT]

Original due date: [DATE]

Days overdue: [NUMBER]

This is my [FIRST / SECOND / THIRD] follow-up

Tone: professional and firm. First follow-up = assume it slipped through. Second = clear expectation. Third = serious but not hostile. Under 100 words each version.

Write one version appropriate for where I am in the sequence.

Section E: Business Development (10 prompts)

E1 – Content idea generation

I want to create content (LinkedIn posts, a newsletter, or short articles) to attract [IDEAL CLIENT TYPE] clients.

My specialty: [SPECIALTY]

What my ideal clients struggle with: [PAIN POINTS]

What I know that they don't: [YOUR EXPERTISE]

Generate 15 specific content ideas. For each, give: topic, angle (why it's interesting), and the one key insight or takeaway. Prioritize ideas that demonstrate expertise, not just awareness.

E2 – LinkedIn post draft

Write a LinkedIn post about [TOPIC].

My audience: [AUDIENCE – e.g., "marketing directors at B2B tech companies"]

The main insight or story: [DESCRIBE]

What I want them to take away: [TAKEAWAY]

Format: hook in the first line (no "I'm excited to share" openers), short paragraphs, one concrete insight, end with a question or call to action. Under 250 words. Sound like a knowledgeable human, not a content marketer.

E3 – Newsletter issue outline

I write a [FREQUENCY] newsletter for [AUDIENCE – e.g., "freelance consultants"].

Topic for this issue: [TOPIC]

Key point I want to make: [POINT]

Personal story or example I can include: [BRIEF DESCRIPTION OR "none"]

Outline a newsletter issue with: subject line (5 options), intro hook, main content structure (3–4 sections), and a call to action. Keep the outline tight – I'm writing the content, just need the structure.

E4 – Define ideal client profile

Help me define my ideal client profile (ICP).

My service: [SERVICE]

Clients I've loved working with: [DESCRIBE 2–3]

Clients I've disliked: [DESCRIBE 1–2 WITHOUT NAMING]

My best results came from: [DESCRIBE SITUATION]

Based on this, describe my ICP across these dimensions: industry, company size, role/title, situation they're in (what triggers them to hire someone like me), what they value in a vendor, red flags to watch for.

E5 – Partnership pitch

I want to propose a referral or collaboration partnership to [PERSON/COMPANY – e.g., "a web designer who works with my same clients"].

What I can offer them: [WHAT YOU BRING]

What they could offer me: [WHAT THEY BRING]

Why it benefits their clients: [CLIENT BENEFIT]

Write a short message proposing the partnership. Under 150 words. Feel like a genuine suggestion, not a pitch deck.

E6 – Analyze a competitor's positioning

Here's a competitor's website copy or bio: [PASTE THEIR TEXT]

Analyze:

1. How they're positioning themselves
2. The clients they seem to target
3. Their key differentiators
4. What they don't address or a gap in their positioning
5. One thing I could learn from them, and one thing I could do differently

Be specific and honest, not cheerleading.

E7 – Price anchoring strategy

I offer [YOUR SERVICE] and currently charge [YOUR RATE].

Help me design a 3-tier pricing structure that:

1. Makes my target price feel like the obvious middle choice
2. Has a genuine lower option (smaller scope, not just lower price)
3. Has a genuine premium option with real added value
4. Makes it easy for clients to say yes

For each tier, describe the scope, the price logic, and who it's for.

E8 – Annual business review prompts

I want to do an annual review of my freelance business. Give me 15 specific questions to reflect on across these areas: revenue and clients (what worked, what didn't), skills and development, work quality and satisfaction, systems and efficiency, and goals for next year.

Each question should prompt honest reflection, not just summary. Include at least 2 uncomfortable questions.

E9 – Waitlist/limited availability message

I'm fully booked until [DATE] and want to let prospects know without losing them.

Write a short, professional message for my website or email that:

1. States my current availability honestly
2. Creates some urgency (limited spots)
3. Makes it easy to get on my list for when I'm available
4. Doesn't sound fake-busy or manipulative

Under 100 words.

E10 – 90-day growth plan

I want to grow my freelance income by [GOAL – e.g., "25%"] over the next 90 days.

Current situation:

- Services: [YOUR SERVICES]
- Current revenue: [APPROXIMATE]
- Main bottleneck (your honest read): [BOTTLENECK – e.g., "not enough leads," "low conversion," "too slow delivery," "low rates"]

Give me a concrete 90-day plan with specific actions by month. Focus on the highest-leverage moves for my specific bottleneck. Be realistic, not motivational.

Section F: Admin & Operations (9 prompts)

F1 – Invoice draft

Write the line items for an invoice for the following project:

Client: [CLIENT TYPE – no names if needed]

Project: [PROJECT DESCRIPTION]

What was delivered: [LIST OF DELIVERABLES]

Total agreed price: [PRICE]

Payment terms: [E.G., "net 15," "due on receipt"]

Late fee policy: [OR "none"]

Format as a professional invoice line-item structure I can paste into my invoicing tool. Include a brief project description at the top.

F2 – Contract clause review

Here is a contract clause a client sent me: [PASTE CLAUSE]

Explain in plain English:

1. What this clause means
2. Whether it's standard or unusual
3. Any risk it poses to me as a freelancer
4. Whether I should push back, and what I could ask for instead

Note: this is informational only – I'll consult a lawyer for anything significant.

F3 – End-of-year tax prep checklist

Create an end-of-year tax preparation checklist for a self-employed freelancer in [COUNTRY/REGION].

Include: income documentation, expense categories to review, deductions commonly missed by freelancers, things to do before December 31st vs. things that can wait until filing, and a list of documents to have ready for an accountant.

Note: this is a general checklist, not legal or tax advice.

F4 – Project retrospective

A project just ended. Help me run a quick retrospective.

Project: [BRIEF DESCRIPTION]

What went well: [YOUR NOTES]

What didn't go well: [YOUR NOTES]

What I'd do differently: [YOUR INITIAL THOUGHTS]

Organize my notes into a structured retrospective summary with: 3 wins to build on, 3 lessons learned, and 3 specific changes to make to my process for the next similar project.

F5 – Draft a client contract (framework)

Create a plain-English freelance services agreement framework for [TYPE OF SERVICE – e.g., "copywriting" / "web design" / "consulting"].

Include sections for: scope of work (placeholder), payment terms, revision policy, intellectual property/ownership, confidentiality, kill fee, late payment, and termination.

Write each section in clear, non-legalese language. Flag which sections I should have a lawyer review before using with real clients.

F6 – Expense categorization help

Here is a list of my business expenses from this [MONTH/QUARTER]: [PASTE LIST]

Categorize each into standard freelance business expense categories (e.g., software/subscriptions, professional development, marketing, equipment, home office, travel, etc.).

Flag any that might not be fully deductible and explain why. Note: I'll verify with my accountant.

F7 – Set up a client portal structure

I want to set up a simple client portal using [TOOL – e.g., Notion, Google Drive, ClickUp].

Type of work I do: [YOUR SERVICE]

Typical project duration: [DURATION]

What clients most need: [E.G., "to see progress, access deliverables, give feedback"]

Design a folder/page structure for the portal that covers: project overview, shared files, communication log, feedback rounds, invoicing, and final delivery. Keep it simple enough that clients actually use it.

F8 – Automate a repetitive process

I repeatedly do this task in my business: [DESCRIBE TASK – e.g., "write the same type of onboarding email for every new client," "create the same report structure every month"]

What are the steps I always follow? [LIST THE STEPS]

Help me create a repeatable template or system for this so I never build it from scratch again. Include: a template I can reuse, the 3–4 things I need to customize each time, and any parts that AI could help draft for me.

F9 – Capacity planning

Here is my current project load:

[LIST YOUR ACTIVE PROJECTS AND ESTIMATED HOURS PER WEEK]

My target working hours per week: [HOURS]

Buffer I want to keep for admin, business development, and surprises: [HOURS OR PERCENTAGE]

Calculate how much capacity I have for new work. If I'm over capacity, suggest which project types to defer or which tasks to batch. If I have capacity, suggest what type of new project would fit.

End of Prompt Library · 55 prompts across 6 categories

Continue to: 03 – Client Workflows →

03 – Client Workflows

AI-powered processes for every phase of client work

Overview

This section gives you a repeatable process for each phase of client work. Each workflow tells you: what to do, which AI prompts to use (referencing the prompt library), and what the output looks like.

Work through each workflow once on a real project. After that, it becomes muscle memory.

Workflow 1: Pre-Discovery (Before the First Call)

Time needed: 20–30 minutes

When to use: As soon as a lead confirms a discovery call

Steps

Step 1 – Research the company (10 min)

Use prompt **A1** to build a quick brief on the company. Feed it anything public you've found: their website, LinkedIn, any news. Your goal: know their context, likely pain points, and relevant vocabulary before the call.

Step 2 – Prepare discovery questions (10 min)

Use prompt **B1** with the context from Step 1. Print or keep open during the call.

Step 3 – Set your intention (2 min)

Write down one sentence: "After this call, I will know whether [CONDITION — e.g., 'this is a fit for my services and what a project scope would look like']."

This forces you to be outcome-focused, not just conversational.

Output: A 1-page pre-call brief with company context + your discovery questions.

Workflow 2: Scoping & Proposal

Time needed: 1–3 hours

When to use: After a successful discovery call

Steps

Step 1 – Debrief the discovery call (15 min)

Immediately after the call, write a rough brain-dump of notes: what they said, what you noticed, what you're not sure about, what you'd need to do the project.

Step 2 – Identify risks (10 min)

Use prompt **B5** with your notes. Take any risks seriously — better to flag them now than to live with them for 3 months.

Step 3 – Draft the scope of work (30–60 min)

Use prompt **B2**. The key discipline here: be specific about what's NOT included. This is where projects blow up. Review the output carefully and add your own exclusions.

Step 4 – Price the project

Use the rate-setting worksheet in file 04. Don't skip this step — guessing rates leads to resentment.

Step 5 – Write the proposal

Structure:

1. **The situation** — their problem in your words (shows you listened)
2. **The goal** — what success looks like
3. **My approach** — how you'll work, your process, key decisions
4. **What's included** — your SOW (from Step 3)
5. **Investment** — your fee (with tiered options if relevant, see prompt E7)
6. **Timeline** — key milestones
7. **Next steps** — what they need to do

Use prompt **C4** to outline each section, then write the content yourself.

Step 6 – Send the proposal email

Use prompt **B3** to write the covering email.

Output: A complete proposal document + covering email, ready to send.

Workflow 3: Client Onboarding

Time needed: 1–2 hours

When to use: After the client signs and pays the first invoice

Steps

Step 1 – Create the project brief

Use prompt **B6** to generate a brief template for your type of work. Send it to the client with a 5-business-day deadline to complete it. Make clear that the project timeline starts when you receive it.

Step 2 – Set up the client portal

Use prompt **F7** to design the folder/page structure. Keep it simple: most clients won't use anything complex.

Step 3 – Schedule the kickoff meeting

Use prompt **B8** to create the agenda. Send it 24 hours in advance.

Step 4 – Run the kickoff

Stick to the agenda. The most important outcome: alignment on what "done" looks like and who's responsible for what. Write it down and send a follow-up summary within 2 hours of the call.

Step 5 – Send the kickoff summary

Immediately after: paste your notes into AI with this instruction:

"Turn these rough notes into a clean kickoff meeting summary with: decisions made, next steps (with owner and deadline), and open questions. Bullet points, under 300 words."

Send to the client. This builds confidence and creates a written record.

Output: Completed brief, project portal, kickoff summary.

Workflow 4: Project Execution

Time needed: Ongoing

When to use: Throughout the project

Weekly rhythm

Monday: Review the project brief and your deliverables list. Write your 3 priorities for the week. Note anything you need from the client this week.

Daily work:

- Use prompts **C1–C10** as needed for research, drafting, reviewing, and simplifying.
- Start with an outline (C4) before drafting anything substantial.
- Run your drafts through a self-review before client delivery.

Friday (or end of your work week):

- Send a status update using prompt **D1**.
- Note anything that changed from the original scope.
- Flag risks or delays early — always better to tell clients before a deadline than after.

Before any delivery:

Run the quality-control checklist from prompt **C9**. If you don't have one for your deliverable type yet, create one and save it.

Managing scope creep

Scope creep is normal. The question is how you handle it.

When a client asks for something outside scope:

1. Don't say "no" — say "yes, and here's what that looks like."
2. Use prompt **B4** to draft the response.
3. Decide whether to add it to the current project (for a fee) or queue it for a follow-on project.

The rule: **every time you do out-of-scope work for free, you train the client to ask for more.**

Workflow 5: Delivery & Close

Time needed: 1–2 hours

When to use: When the project is complete

Steps

Step 1 – Pre-delivery review (30 min)

Run the QC checklist (C9). Review the original brief: did you deliver everything? Does it match what they asked for? Fix anything before sending.

Step 2 – Write the delivery email

Use prompt **D2**. Call out 1–2 key decisions you made and why. This shows expertise and makes the client feel confident in the work.

Step 3 – Manage the feedback round

Set a clear deadline for feedback (5–7 business days is standard). After that, if the project needs further rounds, specify the revision policy.

When feedback comes in:

- If constructive: use prompt **D3** to respond, make the changes, re-deliver.
- If unclear: ask clarifying questions before doing any work.
- If outside scope: treat like scope creep (prompt B4).

Step 4 – Close the project

Use prompt **D6** for the closing email. Include any handoff notes (logins, files, next steps they own).

Step 5 – Ask for a testimonial

Use prompt **D7**. Do this within 48 hours of closing — it's when enthusiasm is highest.

Step 6 – Invoice final payment

Send the final invoice using prompt **F1** and add a note thanking them for the project. Don't let final invoices sit — send immediately.

Step 7 – Run your retrospective (15 min)

Use prompt **F4** within one week. This is how you improve with every project.

Output: Final delivery, testimonial request, invoice, retrospective notes.

Workflow 6: Re-engagement & Referrals

Time needed: 30–60 minutes per quarter

When to use: 3–6 months after project completion, and quarterly thereafter

Steps

Step 1 – Client audit

Quarterly, review your past clients. For each: did we get a good result? Would I work with them again? Are they the type to refer others?

Step 2 – Re-engagement messages

For your top 5 past clients, send a short check-in (not a sales pitch). Something like:

"Hey [Name] — just thinking about [PROJECT]. Hope things are going well with [OUTCOME]. I'm working on a few projects in your space and thought of you. Any big challenges on your plate I might be able to help with?"

Use prompt **A7** to craft referral requests for your best-fit clients.

Step 3 – Referral program (simple)

If you don't have one, add one line to your closing emails:

"I grow almost entirely through referrals. If you know someone who could use [YOUR SERVICE], I'd be grateful for an introduction."

That's it. No incentive needed for most freelancers — happy clients refer when asked.

Output: A short list of re-engagement messages sent, plus a referral touchpoint added to your closing workflow.

Continue to: 04 – Proposals & Rate Templates →

04 – Proposals & Rate Templates

A winning proposal structure + a rate-setting worksheet

Part 1: The Rate-Setting Worksheet

Most freelancers undercharge. The usual culprit: rates set by guessing what "feels right" or matching what they've seen others charge. This worksheet replaces guessing with math.

Work through all four methods, then use the result to make a confident decision.

Method 1: The Minimum Viable Rate

Step 1 – Calculate your monthly expenses

Category	Monthly Amount
Housing (rent/mortgage)	\$_____
Food	\$_____
Transportation	\$_____
Health insurance	\$_____
Business software/tools	\$_____
Professional development	\$_____
Taxes set-aside (25–35% of income)	\$_____
Savings/retirement target	\$_____
Everything else	\$_____
TOTAL MONTHLY NEED	\$_____

Step 2 – Calculate your billable hours

Working days per month (typically 20–22): _____

Hours you can realistically bill per day (note: not all work hours are billable): _____

Billable hours per month: _____

Typical breakdown: if you work 40 hrs/week, realistically ~50–60% is billable. So $40 \text{ hrs} \times 0.55 \times 4.3 \text{ weeks} \approx \mathbf{94 \text{ billable hours/month}}$. Use your own number.

Step 3 – Minimum hourly rate

Minimum hourly rate = Total Monthly Need ÷ Billable Hours

= \$_____ ÷ _____ = \$_____ /hour

This is your floor. Never go below it. Most freelancers find this is actually higher than what they're currently charging.

Method 2: The Market Rate Check

Research what freelancers in your specialty and experience level are charging. Sources (as of 2026):

- Freelancer community forums and subreddits for your specialty
- Job boards that list freelance rates
- Direct conversations with peers (more accurate than any survey)
- Freelance rate databases (various by industry)

What you're looking for: the range for someone with your experience and specialty. Not the median — the top 25%.

Market rate range you found: \$_____ – \$_____ /hour

Top 25% rate: \$_____ /hour

Method 3: The Value-Based Floor

For project work (not hourly), the right question is: what is this project worth to the client?

Exercise: For your last 3 projects, estimate:

Project	What did it enable the client to do?	Rough value to them (\$)	What you charged (\$)
1			
2			
3			

If your charge is consistently less than 10% of the value created, you're undercharging significantly.

Value-based pricing isn't about charging whatever you want — it's about anchoring your price to impact, not time. If a project will help a client land a \$500K contract, charging \$2,000 is a bargain, and framing it that way makes the sale easier.

Method 4: The Target Rate

What would you need to earn to feel genuinely good about your business?

Annual income target: \$_____

÷ 11 months (1 month buffer for gaps): \$_____ /month

÷ Billable hours per month: _____

= **Target hourly rate: \$_____ /hour**

Rate Decision

Method	Result
Minimum viable rate	\$_____
Market rate (top 25%)	\$_____
Value-based check	Confirms / challenges rate?
Target rate	\$_____
Your rate	\$_____

Rule of thumb: Set your rate at or above the highest of your minimum viable and target rates. If the market supports it, aim for the top 25%.

For project-based pricing: Use your hourly rate to estimate the hours, add 20% buffer, then round to a clean number. Present as a project price, not an hourly rate.

Rate Review Schedule

Trigger	Action
Every 12 months	Review and increase by at least inflation
After a landmark result	Raise immediately for new clients
Consistently closing >75% of proposals	You're priced too low
Consistently struggling to close	May be a value/fit issue, not just price
Raising rates for existing clients	Use prompt D8

Part 2: Winning Proposal Template

Use this structure for any project proposal. Adapt the length to the project — a \$500 project needs 1 page; a \$20,000 project might need 5.

[YOUR NAME OR BUSINESS NAME]

Proposal for: [CLIENT NAME]

Date: [DATE]

Valid for: 14 days

The Situation

[2–4 sentences. Describe their situation in your words — the context, the problem, and why it matters to them. This shows you listened in discovery and understand their world. This is the most persuasive part of the proposal.]

Example:

"Your sales team is generating more leads than ever, but conversion has stalled at 18% — well below your industry benchmark of 31%. After talking with your team, it's clear the issue isn't the leads: it's that the follow-up email sequence drops off after day 3, leaving most prospects with nothing to respond to."

The Goal

[1–3 bullet points. What does success look like? Be specific. If you can attach a number, do.]

- [SPECIFIC OUTCOME 1]
- [SPECIFIC OUTCOME 2]
- [SPECIFIC OUTCOME 3, if applicable]

My Approach

[Describe your process. This builds confidence — it shows you have a method, not just intentions. 3–6 bullet points or short paragraphs.]

Phase 1 – [PHASE NAME] ([TIMEFRAME])

[What you do and why]

Phase 2 – [PHASE NAME] ([TIMEFRAME])

[What you do and why]

Phase 3 – [PHASE NAME] ([TIMEFRAME])

[What you do and why]

Include what you need from the client in each phase. This sets expectations early.

What's Included

- ✓ [DELIVERABLE 1]
- ✓ [DELIVERABLE 2]
- ✓ [DELIVERABLE 3]
- ✓ [NUMBER] rounds of revisions
- ✓ [ANYTHING ELSE]

Not included:

- ✗ [EXPLICIT EXCLUSION 1 — e.g., "Copywriting for any pages not listed above"]

- ✗ [EXPLICIT EXCLUSION 2 — e.g., "Implementation or development work"]
- ✗ [EXPLICIT EXCLUSION 3 — e.g., "Paid advertising strategy or management"]

Additional work outside this scope can be quoted separately.

Investment

Option	What's Included	Investment
[OPTION NAME 1]	[BRIEF DESCRIPTION]	[\$[PRICE]]
[OPTION NAME 2 — Recommended]	[BRIEF DESCRIPTION]	[\$[PRICE]]
[OPTION NAME 3]	[BRIEF DESCRIPTION]	[\$[PRICE]]

Or, if single option:

Total Investment: \$[PRICE]

Payment terms: [E.G., "50% on signing, 50% on delivery" / "100% upfront" / "Monthly billing"]

Timeline

Milestone	Date
Project kickoff	[DATE after signing + 3–5 days]
[DELIVERABLE 1]	[DATE]
[DELIVERABLE 2]	[DATE]
Client feedback round	[DATE]
Final delivery	[DATE]

Timeline begins when signed contract and first payment are received.

About Me

[2–4 sentences. Who you are, relevant experience, and one specific result relevant to this type of project. This isn't a biography — it's a confidence-builder.]

Next Steps

To move forward:

1. Reply to this email with any questions
2. Sign the attached agreement
3. Pay the first invoice ([AMOUNT])

I'll schedule the kickoff call immediately after both are received.

This proposal is valid for 14 days from the date above. I hold time in my schedule for confirmed projects only.

[YOUR NAME]

[CONTACT INFORMATION]

[WEBSITE]

Part 3: Proposal Covering Email Template

(Also see prompt B3 in the Prompt Library)

Subject: Proposal for [PROJECT NAME] — [CLIENT NAME]

Hi [NAME],

Attached is my proposal for [PROJECT DESCRIPTION].

The short version: [ONE SENTENCE SUMMARY OF YOUR APPROACH AND WHAT IT ACHIEVES].

A few things I want to flag:

- [IMPORTANT THING 1 — e.g., "I've built in two weeks for your team's review round — let me know if that timeline needs adjusting"]
- [IMPORTANT THING 2 — e.g., "I included three options so you can choose the scope that fits your budget"]

[OPTIONAL: One piece of social proof — e.g., "I recently did similar work for [CLIENT TYPE] and achieved [RESULT]."]

Happy to get on a call if any questions come up. Otherwise, just reply with questions or sign and we'll get started.

[YOUR NAME]

Continue to: 05 – Weekly AI System →

05 – The Weekly AI System

A 90-minute Friday routine to keep your freelance business growing

Why a Weekly System?

Most freelancers live in reaction mode. They finish projects, invoice, find the next thing in a panic, repeat. The cycle feels busy but it's not compound growth — it's a treadmill.

A weekly system changes that. 90 minutes every Friday (or whenever your work week ends) turns your business from reactive to intentional. Give it 12 weeks before judging whether it works for you.

The Full 90-Minute Block

Set a timer for 90 minutes. No meetings. No emails (except what the system asks you to send). Work through these five parts in order.

Part 1 – Weekly Review (20 minutes)

What to do:

Open a doc and write raw answers to these questions. Don't edit — just write.

1. What did I complete this week?
2. What didn't I complete? Why?
3. Where did time go that I didn't plan for?
4. What would have made this week better?
5. What's the single most important thing I learned this week?

Then:

Paste your answers into AI with this prompt:

"Here are my weekly review notes. Identify: (1) one pattern across the items, (2) one thing I seem to be avoiding, (3) one specific process improvement I should make next week."

Read the output. Sit with it. You don't have to act on all of it — but if something resonates, write it down as a change.

Part 2 – Client Health Check (15 minutes)

For each active client, answer:

Client	Deliverable status	Any concerns?	What do they need from me next week?	Am I behind on anything?
[CLIENT 1]				
[CLIENT 2]				
[CLIENT 3]				

Action items:

- If any client hasn't heard from you this week: send a status update (prompt D1).
- If any deliverable is at risk: flag it now (prompt D4).
- If any client seems unhappy: address it before the weekend (prompt D9).

Rule: No client should go more than 5 business days without a touchpoint during an active project.

Part 3 – Pipeline & Business Development (20 minutes)

Review your prospect list:

Prospect	Last contact	Status	Next action	By when
[PROSPECT 1]				
[PROSPECT 2]				
[PROSPECT 3]				

Questions to answer:

1. Do I have enough in the pipeline to hit next month's income goal? (If no: what's one BD action I can take today?)
2. Is there a past client I haven't spoken to in 3+ months? (If yes: send a check-in today.)
3. Is there a referral I should ask for? (If yes: use prompt A7 and send it today.)

Content and visibility (5 min):

If you're building an audience (newsletter, LinkedIn, etc.):

- Did I publish anything this week?
- Is there one thing I learned or observed this week that would be useful to my audience?
- If yes: spend 5 minutes drafting a post using prompt E2. If it's good, post it now.

Part 4 – Finance Check (15 minutes)

Revenue this month so far: \$_____

Target for this month: \$_____

Gap: \$_____

Outstanding invoices:

Client	Amount	Due Date	Days Overdue
--------	--------	----------	--------------

Action: Any invoice overdue by 7+ days? Send a reminder today (prompt D10).

Upcoming invoices to send:

Client	Milestone	Invoice Amount	Send by
--------	-----------	----------------	---------

Monthly run rate:

Compare this month to last 3 months. Are you trending up, flat, or down? If down two months in a row: treat it as a signal to double BD effort, not just wait.

Part 5 – Next Week Setup (20 minutes)

Step 1 – Prioritize next week

Write your top 3 deliverables for next week:

1. _____ (for client _____, due _____)
2. _____ (for client _____, due _____)
3. _____ (for client _____, due _____)

These go in your calendar as time blocks before anything else.

Step 2 – Identify what needs AI help

Look at your top 3 deliverables. For each:

- Which phase has the most uncertainty? → Plan to use AI for research or outlining first.
- Which phase is the most time-consuming? → Plan to use AI for first drafts.
- Which phase requires the most expertise? → Block time for focused work, no AI shortcut.

Step 3 – Capture any process improvements

From Part 1, what process change did you decide to make? Write it as a specific action:

"Next week I will [SPECIFIC CHANGE] in order to [EXPECTED BENEFIT]."

Write it where you'll see it.

Step 4 – Clear your head

Write down anything that's been bugging you — a client situation, a financial concern, an uncomfortable conversation you've been avoiding. Just getting it on paper reduces its mental weight.

Then: for each item, write one concrete next step. Even if it's tiny. "Respond to [NAME]'s email" is enough.

Monthly Add-On (First Friday of Each Month)

On the first Friday of each month, add 30 minutes and do this:

1. Monthly income & goal review (10 min)

- Income this month vs. goal
- Compare to last 3 months
- Are rates creeping up or staying flat?

2. Client audit (10 min)

- Which clients am I doing my best work for?
- Which clients are the most enjoyable?
- Which are the most stressful?
- Any client I should wind down or raise rates with?

3. Skills and development check (10 min)

- What's one skill I should develop over the next 90 days?
- What's one piece of content (course, book, community) I should engage with this month?

Use prompt **E8** for a deeper quarterly version.

Quarterly Add-On (First Friday of Q2, Q3, Q4)

Once per quarter, do the full **Annual Business Review** (prompt **E8**, adapted for quarterly use).

Key questions:

1. Am I on track to hit my annual income goal?
 2. What's my highest-revenue service or client type? Am I leaning into it?
 3. What am I still doing that I should stop?
 4. What's one thing I'll do differently next quarter?
-

Template: The Weekly Log

Keep a running weekly log. Each week, add one entry:

Week of: [DATE]

What I completed:

—
—

Wins:

—

Friction points:

—

BD actions taken:

—

Key learning:

Next week priorities:

1.
2.
3.

Process change this week:

After 12 weeks, reviewing your log is one of the most clarifying things you can do. Patterns emerge that you couldn't see week-to-week.

Making It Stick

The hardest part of a weekly system is protecting the time. Some tips:

- **Name it.** "Friday Review" or "CEO Hour" — whatever you call it, make it a calendar event.
 - **Don't skip it, shorten it.** If you have 30 minutes, do parts 2, 3, and 5 only. Don't skip the whole thing.
 - **Keep the log.** The log creates accountability to yourself. It's worth 5 minutes of the 90.
 - **Share it (optional).** Some freelancers share a weekly note with a peer or small community. Accountability compounds the effect.
-

Quick Reference: Which prompt to use when?

Situation	Prompt(s) to use
Before a discovery call	A1, B1
Writing outreach	A2, A3, A4
Scoping a project	B2, B5
Writing a proposal	C4, B2, B3
Doing the work	C1–C10
Communicating with clients	D1–D10
Growing the business	E1–E10
Finance and admin	F1–F9